Dalit families who were affected in the riots were promised protection. A news report suggested that in the first three months of 2014, more than 3000 Dalit youths who were once part of the BSP switched over as full-time BJP workers. ‘We were able to take a large chunk of Mayawati’s votes away from her in western UP,’ claims a local BJP leader.

Just how successful the BJP was with this strategy was confirmed when we did a television programme from a Dalit-dominated village in Noida. The voices were vociferously pro-Modi. *‘Hum Hindu samaj mein hain, Modiji hamare neta hain, iss baar unko hum chance denge’* (We are part of the Hindu community and Modi is our leader. We want to give him a chance). A subdued Mayawati didn’t counter the RSS’s propaganda machine (see chapter 6 for more).

But the even bigger political failure was that of the ruling SP. No major riot in India has taken place without some element of administrative complicity and/or incompetence, be it Delhi 1984 or Gujarat 2002. Muzaffarnagar 2013, in that sense, fitted in with a troubling pattern. As the leader of the party in power, Akhilesh Yadav has much to answer for the partisanship of the local administration. In the winter of 2011–12, he had been UP’s great new hope; less than two years later, he was already becoming its worst nightmare.

~

The 2012 UP assembly elections was a ‘wave’ election—the Samajwadi Party was swept to power by an overwhelming majority. The star turn was that of Akhilesh Yadav who travelled the length and breadth of the state, often on a cycle. Though he bore an uncanny resemblance to father Mulayam, he promised a new face for the SP. He even denied a ticket to D.P. Yadav, the powerful politician with a long criminal record.

While travelling with Akhilesh on the campaign trail, I must confess to being impressed with his desire to change his party’s image. *‘Aap dekh lena, hum UP kee tasveer badal denge’* (Just you wait and see, we will change the face of UP). Young, fresh-faced, foreign educated and,